

World in Brief: America and Iran hold talks in Switzerland; Sir Keir Starmer reportedly set to quit



Photograph: Getty Images

American and **Iranian** officials began talks in Switzerland over the next stage of their [peace deal](#). The vice-president, J. D. Vance, is leading America's delegation, along with two other envoys, Steve Witkoff and Jared Kushner. Meanwhile, Donald Trump threatened to restart strikes on Iran if it did not stop its proxies in Lebanon from "causing trouble". Hizbullah has exchanged strikes with Israel in recent days.

Britain's prime minister, Sir Keir Starmer, is reportedly set to announce his departure from office, perhaps as soon as Monday. Sir Keir has come under renewed pressure since Andy Burnham, the former mayor of Greater Manchester, [won a parliamentary by-election](#), setting up an imminent leadership challenge. Peter Kyle, the business secretary, said the prime minister was reflecting on "political realities".

Mr Trump weighed in on Sir Keir, writing on social media that the prime minister "will resign" and had "failed badly" on the issues of immigration and energy. **America's** president has been stirring trouble with other European leaders, too. He doubled down on claims that Giorgia Meloni begged him for a photo at a recent

meeting. Italy's prime minister firmly denied doing so in two social-media posts.

Ethiopia's prime minister, Abiy Ahmed, won a big victory in this month's parliamentary elections. The National Election Board said his Prosperity Party took 438 out of 486 seats; in dozens of them it faced no opposition. During his [eight years in power](#), Mr Ahmed has achieved rapid economic growth while overseeing a brutal civil war and [stoking tensions](#) with Ethiopia's neighbours, particularly Eritrea.

Ukraine's president, Volodymyr Zelensky, said Ukrainian forces targeted military logistics, oil facilities and air defences in southern **Russia** and **Crimea**. Officials in the occupied peninsula said four people were killed in a drone attack and that sales of fuel at petrol stations would be halted. Ukraine has also stepped up its [long-range strike campaign](#) recently: on Thursday it hit an oil refinery in Moscow.

Israeli attacks on **Gaza** killed at least nine people, according to Palestinian health officials. One strike on a residential building in Gaza city killed four, the officials said, including two women and a child; another on the Bureij refugee camp killed a photojournalist from Al Jazeera, a broadcaster based in Qatar. Israel's armed forces said he was a " Hamas sniper operative".

David Hearn, a former Olympic canoeist, denied vandalising the **Reflecting Pool** in Washington, DC following his arrest on Friday. The Trump administration recently resurfaced the bottom of the pool with a blue coating at a cost of more than \$13m. Algae blooms swiftly returned, and the coating has been seen peeling. Mr Trump said on his social-media site that "many" had been arrested for "vandalism" of the pool.

Word of the week: *Chidehao*, Chinese for "eating well", and what China's Communist Party wants people to do more of. [We explore](#)

the Californication of middle-class Chinese diets.

How closely have you followed the headlines this week? Prove your topical chops in our latest [news quiz](#).

Britain's battle for Downing Street



Photograph: Getty Images

Sir Keir Starmer, Britain's prime minister, is reportedly preparing to step down after his Labour colleague—and rival—Andy Burnham pulled off an **impressive victory** in the Makerfield by-election on Thursday. Mr Burnham, previously the mayor of Greater Manchester, will be sworn in as an MP on Monday, making him eligible to become leader of his party and therefore prime minister. Speaking after his election win, he warned that Britain needs a “new path”. He stopped short of explicitly calling for Sir Keir to quit, but has previously confirmed he is after the top job.

Mr Burnham's backers want the incumbent to depart of his own accord. Sir Keir long insisted he would stay on to fight, but allies suggest he is now reconsidering. Should Sir Keir announce his departure, Mr Burnham could take over unopposed, though other candidates, such as Wes Streeting, the former health secretary, may try to make it a contest. Either way, Mr Burnham will probably end up in 10 Downing Street.

Colombia's run-off election



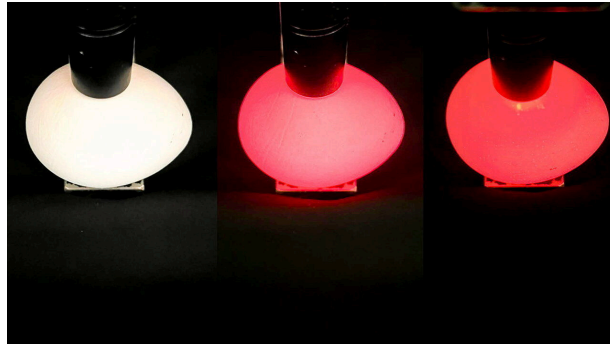
Photograph: Getty Images

On Sunday Colombians vote in a **starkly polarised** presidential run-off. It pits the hard-right Abelardo de la Espriella, a wealthy and controversial former criminal-defence lawyer, against the left-wing candidate, Iván Cepeda, an austere senator and ally of the outgoing president, Gustavo Petro.

Mr de la Espriella is a charismatic campaigner who promises to smash gangs and drug traffickers, build mega-prisons in the jungle and shrink the state. But he also dabbles in populist policies; he promises mortgage rates of 2%, when they are currently 17%. Mr Cepeda, by contrast, carefully reads out his campaign speeches, wants more redistribution of wealth and promises to continue with Mr Petro's strategy of "total peace", which involves negotiating simultaneously with all armed groups. The scheme has so far achieved little.

Mr de la Espriella led the first round of voting and is favourite. Should he triumph, governing will be difficult: Mr Cepeda's party is the biggest in Congress and will relish obstructing the new president's every move.

How to save chicks from the blender



Photograph: Vamshi Damagatla

Eggs have complex topographies. This week in *Newton*, a scientific journal, researchers report that when near-infrared light is shone at an egg, photons hit its inner shell, scattering and reflecting repeatedly, and passing through its interior multiple times. By measuring the time photons spent in the egg, they were able to map its insides. Such “integrating-sphere behaviour” (a property that human eyeballs share) may expose an egg’s quality, fertility and the sex of an embryo.

Hatcheries around the world [cull billions of male chicks](#) a year, using something akin to a blender, since the birds won’t lay eggs nor develop tasty breasts. An easy method for determining the sex of an embryo would remove this wasteful step. It would be a boon to the egg industry and might save chicks from a gory end.

Teen spirit, for museum-goers



Photograph: Debbie Sears (MOYC)

Many people look back on their teenage years with mild embarrassment, regret or envy. Some prefer to forget about them altogether, brushing over the awkward stages between infancy and adulthood. Museums have a tendency to overlook this period, too. There are brilliant institutions dedicated to childhood: the Young v&A in London, for instance, puts everything from dolls to dummies on display. But museums “tend to stop curating at age 14 or 15”, says Lisa Der Weduwe of the Museum of Youth Culture, the first in the world to focus solely on teenagers and young people.

The museum, which surveys a century of adolescent life in Britain, has existed online for some time, but has just opened in London’s Camden neighbourhood. Exhibits reveal how youngsters have shaped culture, from flappers in the 1920s to motor-scooting mods in the 1960s and all the rockers and ravers thereafter.

Weekend profile: Haiti's diaspora World Cup squad



Photograph: Getty Images

It is not unusual for [World Cup](#) footballers to live and play outside the nation they represent. But most at least return to train ahead of the tournament. Not so for Haiti's team. The Caribbean country, which is playing in the World Cup for the first time since 1974, is dominated by [criminal gangs](#). Violent crime is rife and the state barely functions. As such, the national team almost exclusively consists of players based elsewhere. Many have never been to the country. Haiti had to play their home qualifying matches 500 miles away in Curaçao.

Only one of the team lives in Haiti. Woodensky Pierre, a midfielder, plays for local champions Violette Athletic Club. He was late joining his teammates at their training camp in Florida because of an American travel ban on Haiti. He was only given a visa on June 1st.

The team's French coach, Sébastien Migné, has never been to Haiti either. But he is used to leading teams from volatile places. He has spent much of his career in Africa, and was the assistant coach for the national side of the Democratic Republic of Congo when the country was caught in an internal armed conflict. To build a Haitian team he persuaded talented footballers who are eligible to play to sign on. The two most famous members of the Haitian squad, Jean-

Ricner Bellegarde and Wilson Isidor, are French-born Migne converts. The pair spent last year in the English Premier League.

One of Haiti's squad, Duckens Nazon, escaped another conflict in his journey to the World Cup. Last year the striker signed for Esteghlal, one of the most successful clubs in Iran. When war began in February, Mr Nazon had a hair-raising trip out of the country.

But Haiti's footballers have come together more successfully than its politicians. The country has cycled through transitional councils since gangs forced out the last elected government in 2016. Order, such as it is, depends on a UN-backed Gang Suppression Force. America bankrolls that mission, yet shows little sympathy for Haitians' plight. Donald Trump's administration has tried to strip some 350,000 Haitians in America of their protected status—a move blocked, for now, by a federal judge.

The conflict-racked country could do with a brief burst of elation. But Haiti's World Cup is unlikely to last long. They share a group with Brazil (five-time winners) and Morocco (semi-finalists in 2022). They lost against Scotland on June 14th. But Mr Migné knows that the World Cup can defy logic. In 2022 he was the assistant coach for Cameroon. The team provided one of the tournament's most joyous moments when they beat Brazil 1-0 with a last-minute winner. Haitians will dream of a similar upset this year.

The winners of this week's quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Willy Zimmer, Casper, Wyoming

Nalin, Tanjong Pagar, Singapore.

Frank Jansse, Brussels, Belgium

They all gave the correct answers of: a cow, the hand, School's Out, Thomas Haden Church, The Great Fire of London. The theme is bells: cow bell, handbell, school bell, church bell and fire bell

The questions were:

Monday: *La vache qui rit* is a French cheese brand featuring which animal?

Tuesday: What title is given to the chief adviser to a ruler in the Game of Thrones series?

Wednesday: Which rebellious song was Alice Cooper's greatest hit?

Thursday: Who was nominated for his role as best supporting actor in the film Sideways?

Friday: What great event began at a bakery in Pudding Lane in 1666?

Mini crossword

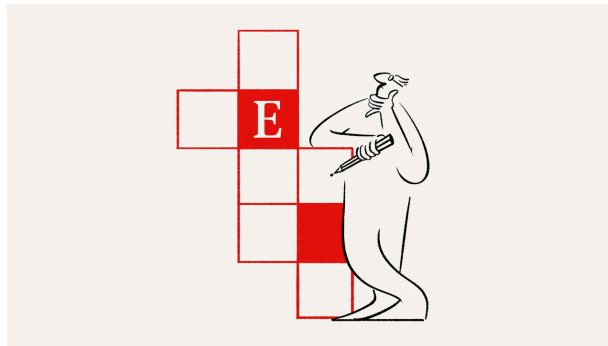


Illustration: The Economist

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Charles Rex heads American bottom? A bit rude (5)

2 across - Average and not very nice (4)

3 across - Propeller spins both ways (5)

1 down - Dubious imp hacker gets Intel, for instance (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Crude or insensitive (5)

2 across - The most average average (4)3

3 across - Rotating mechanism (5)

1 down - Nvidia or Intel, for example (9)

Email all four answers, along with your home city and country, by 9am GMT on Monday to [\[email protected\]](#). We will pick three winners at random and crown them in Tuesday's edition.

“I like people who refuse to speak until they are ready to speak.”

Lillian Hellman